Lesson 26 material: Conclusions

4.7: Writing a Conclusion

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

It is not unusual to want to rush when you approach your conclusion, and even experienced writers may fade. But what good writers remember is that it is vital to put just as much attention into the conclusion as in the rest of the essay. After all, a hasty ending can undermine an otherwise strong essay.

A conclusion that does not correspond to the rest of your essay, has loose ends, or is unorganized can unsettle your readers and raise doubts about the entire essay. However, if you have worked hard to write the introduction and body, your conclusion can often be the most logical part to compose.

The Anatomy of a Strong Conclusion

Keep in mind that the ideas in your conclusion must conform to the rest of your essay.In order to tie these components together, restate your thesis at the beginning of your conclusion. This helps you assemble, in an orderly fashion, all the information you have explained in the body. Repeating the exact words of your thesis is usually seen as being redundant, but phrasing the main ideas in different language is a good idea. A strong conclusion reviews your main points and emphasizes the importance of the topic.

The construction of the conclusion is similar to the introduction, in which you make general introductory statements and then present your thesis. The difference is that in the conclusion you first paraphrase, or state in different words, your thesis and then follow up with general concluding remarks. These sentences should progressively broaden the focus of your thesis and maneuver your readers out of the essay.

Many writers like to end their essays with a final emphatic statement. This strong closing statement will cause your readers to continue thinking about the implications of your essay; it will make your conclusion, and thus your essay, more memorable. Another powerful technique is to challenge your readers to make a change in either their thoughts or their actions. Challenging your readers to see the subject through new eyes is a powerful way to ease yourself and your readers out of the essay. Thinking about how your particular topic fits into the larger world view and expressing the wider, global issues is also another technique for ending. Sometimes, this is called the “so, what?” conclusion (as in, why does this issue really matter? Or why is this important?)

Remember that often when the instructor is reading your last paragraph, he or she is deciding on the grade for that paper. Thus, it is important to end your paper skillfully.

It is wise to avoid doing any of the following in your conclusion:

- Introducing new material
- Contradicting your thesis
- Changing your thesis
- Using apologies or disclaimers

Introducing new material in your conclusion has an unsettling effect on your reader.When you raise new points, you make your reader want more information, which you could not possibly provide in the limited space of your final paragraph.

Contradicting or changing your thesis statement causes your readers to think that you do not actually have a conviction about your topic. After all, you have spent several paragraphs adhering to a singular point of view. When you change sides or open up your point of view in the conclusion, your reader becomes less inclined to believe your original argument.

By apologizing for your opinion or stating that you know it is tough to digest, you are in fact admitting that even you know what you have discussed is irrelevant or unconvincing. You do not want your readers to feel this way. Effective writers stand by their thesis statement and do not stray from it.

Make sure your essay is balanced by not having an excessively long or short introduction or conclusion. Check that they match each other in length as closely as possible, and try to mirror the formula you used in each. Parallelism strengthens the message of your essay.

Tip

When closing your essay, do not expressly state that you are drawing to a close. Your reader will know that a conclusion is forthcoming. In advanced academic writing, you would not necessarily rely on statements such as *in conclusion*, *it is clear that*, *as you can see*, or *in summation*. However, until you are more comfortable with essay writing skills, you should feel free to use a transition that indicates a closing.

Writing Your Own First Draft

Now you may begin your own first draft, if you have not already done so. Follow the suggestions and the guidelines presented in this section.

Key Takeaways

- Make the writing process work for you. Use any and all of the strategies that help you move forward in the writing process.
- Always be aware of your purpose for writing and the needs of your audience. Cater to those needs in every sensible way.
- Remember to include all the key structural parts of an essay: a thesis statement that is part of your introductory paragraph, three or more body paragraphs as described in your outline, and a concluding paragraph. Then add an engaging title to draw in readers.
- Write paragraphs of an appropriate length for your writing assignment. Paragraphs in college-level writing can be a page long, as long as they cover the main topics in your outline.

- Use your outline to guide the development of your paragraphs and the elaboration of your ideas. Each main idea, indicated by a roman numeral in your outline, becomes the topic of a new paragraph. Develop it with the supporting details and the subpoints of those details that you included in your outline.
- Generally speaking, write your introduction and conclusion last, after you have fleshed out the body paragraphs.
- A conclusion that does not connect to the rest of the essay can diminish the effect of your paper.
- The conclusion should remain true to your thesis statement. It is best to avoid changing your tone or your main idea and avoid introducing any new material.
- Closing with a final emphatic statement or a thoughtful reflection provides closure for your readers and makes your essay more memorable.

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4.8: Writing Essays (Exercises)

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

1. On a separate sheet of paper, choose one of the examples of a proper thesis statement from this chapter (one that interests you) and form three supporting points for that statement. After you have formed your three points, write a topic sentence for each body paragraph. Make sure that your topic sentences can be backed up with examples and details.
2. On a separate sheet of a paper, write an introduction for an essay based on the thesis statement from the group activity using the techniques for introductory paragraphs that you learned in this chapter.
3. Start a journal in which you record “spoken” thesis statements. Start listening closely to the opinions expressed by your teachers, classmates, friends, and family members. Ask them to provide at least three reasons for their opinion and record them in the journal. Use this as material for future essays.
4. Open a magazine and read a lengthy article. See if you can pinpoint the thesis statement as well as the topic sentence for each paragraph and its supporting details.

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2.6: Writing a Conclusion Paragraph

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The main parts of a conclusion

The conclusion, or concluding paragraph, is the final paragraph in the essay. Because it is put at the end, it is the last paragraph your readers will read. It will wrap up your ideas and leave them something to think about. Having a strong conclusion will help to leave a clear idea in the reader's mind.

With the introduction you started with a broader idea (the hook) and got more specific as you moved through the background section, until you got to the very focused thesis statement. In a conclusion you will do the opposite. You will start with the specific ideas in your paper and move outwards, ending on a bigger idea that is related to your topic but not covered in the body paragraphs.

The three main parts of a conclusion are

- Umbrella sentence
- Summary
- Food for thought

Let's look at each of them in more detail.

Umbrella sentence

The umbrella sentence is one sentence that gives the main idea of your whole paper. It is similar to your thesis, but it should have **different words** and can also be a little simpler. It is called an umbrella sentence because one sentence covers all the points of your essay, just like an umbrella covers all of your body and protects you from the rain (see figure 2.6.1).

(Picture: Person holding an umbrella)

Figure: "her umbrella" by Pedro Moura Pinheiro is marked with CC BY-NC-SA 2.0.

Let's compare a thesis statement with an umbrella sentence:

Here is a student's thesis statement: “The problem with stereotypes is not that they are untrue, but that they are incomplete, and make one story become the only story.”

A possible umbrella sentence could be: “Stereotypes are harmful because they present flawed and incomplete views of a person or a group of people.”

Notice how the umbrella sentence covers the same general information as the thesis statement, but is less detailed.

Summary

Remind the reader of the points you made in your essay so they can see how everything fits together. Summarize the main idea of each paragraph in 1to 3 sentences. Try to change the words so you are not using the exact same language as your topic sentences.

Identifying the summary

Let's see what that looks like:

Notice this!

Read the following conclusion. The sentences [in brackets] are summary sentences that indicate the contents of the writer’s body paragraphs.

Stereotypes are harmful because they present flawed and incomplete views that can lead to prejudice. [On an individual level, they take away a person’s true identity; a person is given a label based on a group identity that cannot accurately be applied to each person. On a societal level, stereotypes can lead to policies that discriminate against particular groups of people. Stereotypes can also lead to physical violence, as in the examples of the anti-Muslim mosque attacks and anti-Semitic synagogue attacks in Southern California.] By working hard to combat our own biases and speaking up when we see a “single story” dominate, we can lessen the damaging impact of stereotypes and make the world a safer, more equitable place.

Food for thought

Finally, give some final idea to leave the reader thinking. We call this "food for thought" because the reader will need to spend some time pondering and digesting it, just as you spend some time eating and digesting food (see figure 2.6.2). Basically, as you say goodbye to your reader you want them to keep thinking about the ideas in your essay and why these ideas are important. Your food for thought can be:

- a suggestion
- an explanation of why this is important or what you want readers to learn
- a reflection on how your own thinking changed through writing this.
- a prediction or warning for the future
- return to the hook from the introduction with an explanation of how the knowledge we have gained through your paper changes our understanding of it (this makes your paper feel like a full circle, and can be satisfying for the reader)

(Picture: ice cream cone)

Figure :"ice-cream" by EEPaul is marked with CC BY 2.0.

Identifying food for thought

Let's see what some of these look like:

Try this!

Can you identify what type of food for thought is shown in each of the following sentences?

1. By working hard to combat our own biases and speaking up when we see a “single story” dominate, we can lessen the damaging impact of stereotypes and make the world a safer, more equitable place.
2. Researching the topic of bias revealed some large gaps in my understanding, and now I realize that more than ever, identifying and addressing our own personal biases is critical.
3. Although it may be easier to avoid the potential discomfort of considering more than a “single story” about a person or group of people, failure to take multiple stories into account risks a bleak, increasingly polarized future.

(For possible answers, check the 2.15: Answer Key: Organization and Cohesion.)

Identifying the parts of a conclusion

Let's see if you can identify the main parts of a conclusion:

Try this!

Here is the conclusion to the summary/response essay we looked at earlier in this chapter. Can you find the umbrella sentence, summary, and food for thought?

In “Stereotype Threat,” McRaney and her colleagues clearly and evenhandedly explain the phenomenon of stereotype threat. Their choice of language makes the chapter interesting and accessible to students who may not have training in the social sciences, even as the authors cite many academic sources. The authors also spend time addressing and responding to some common criticisms of and doubts about the existence of stereotype threat, which makes the ideas they discuss more credible. Furthermore, the content is relatable: the examples provided in the text helped me identify an instance of stereotype threat in my own life and made me think about other situations where stereotype threat may have been at play. Their chapter highlights an important phenomenon and, with this knowledge, institutions and individuals can take steps to create environments in and out of the classroom that lessen the chance stereotype threat will negatively (and needlessly) affect performance.

(For possible answers, check the 2.15: Answer Key: Organization and Cohesion.)

Writing your conclusion

Let's put this all together in your own writing:

Apply this!

Look at a draft of your writing, focusing on the conclusion.

- Can you identify the three main elements of a conclusion?
- Is your umbrella sentence directly connected to, but not exactly the same as, your thesis statement?
- Does your summary address all the topics in your body paragraphs? (Hint: Look at the topic sentences in each body paragraph; this should help you answer this question.)
- What information do you leave your reader with in the very last sentence? A suggestion? A return to your hook? Or something else?

Section review

- The conclusion, or concluding paragraph, is the final paragraph in your essay.
- A strong conclusion will help to leave a clear idea in the reader's mind.
- The three main parts of a conclusion are:
    1. Umbrella sentence
    2. Summary
    3. Food for thought

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